conflict with the Soviet Union.' Doesn't that statement mean that the president of the United States wants to incite me, as head of the Soviet government, to compete with him as to who will 'push the button' first?" Khrushchev said that he was opposed to such a competition. He then added: "The president of the United States of America made an ill-advised statement. Is it wise to threaten someone who is at least as strong as you? Pushing the button and taking 'the initiative in a nuclear conflict with the Soviet Union' would actually mean committing suicide."[15]

As Khrushchev knew better than anyone, the American and Soviet nuclear missile arsenals were unequal. He had virtually no rockets capable of reaching the United States to serve as a deterrent. That bothered him a lot, and he would speak of missiles more than once on his Bulgarian trip. At the Black Sea port of Varna, he asked his audience: "Is it not time for the ruling circles of Turkey and neighboring countries to realize the fruitlessness of their course of isolation from their neighbors, a course that subordinates national interests to those of foreign monopolies and senseless preparations for war? Is it not better to turn the shores on which NATO military bases and launchpads for missiles with atomic payloads are located into places of peaceful endeavor and prosperity?"[16]

Khrushchev was referring to the PGM-19 Jupiter medium-range ballistic missiles with 1.44-megaton nuclear warheads that had been deployed by the United States in Italy and Turkey. In February 1961 the Soviet Union had issued a public statement protesting the deployment, to no effect. In June the United States Air Force deployed fifteen Jupiters in Turkey. "The missile base (five launchpads with 15 installations) should be completely ready by March 1962," said a report from the Soviet embassy in Ankara to Moscow in early 1962. "By the end of the year the number of American military and civilian personnel, including family members, had reached a record figure—120,000 persons." Given that the Jupiter had a range of 2,400 kilometers, and the distance from the environs of Izmir in Turkey, where the missiles were placed, to Moscow was 2,080 kilometers, the Americans could now easily strike Moscow.[17]

Khrushchev had little expectation that the Turks would follow his advice and return the American missiles. Instead, as claimed by his son Sergei, while walking in a Varna seaside park he had a eureka moment: he